

The Clockmaker of Blue Harbor

A 20-page public-domain-style sample story for translation testing

Page 1

Chapter One: The Bell That Ran Backward

At six each evening, the harbor bell rang twelve times and made everyone in Blue Harbor look toward the old clock tower. Mina Vale was the only person who noticed that the final note always arrived before the first. Her grandfather had built the tower, and he had left her a brass key no larger than a fingernail.

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"If time can be borrowed," Tomas said, "then it can also be returned." Mina did not answer immediately. She was listening to the gears behind the wall, counting how many of them sounded afraid.

By the end of the page, the harbor had changed again: windows glowed, ropes tightened, and every boat pointed toward the lighthouse as if the sea had whispered a direction only wood could understand.

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Chapter Two: Salt on the Mechanism - continued

The tower smelled of rain, salt, and old paper. Every stair groaned like it remembered a heavier century. Mina found a cabinet filled with gears labeled by weather: fog, spring tide, thunder, apology, and return. The last drawer was empty except for a note that said, Do not wind what you cannot forgive.

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Chapter Three: A Map of Missing Minutes

Her friend Tomas brought a lantern and a sailor's map. The map showed streets that had never existed and alleys that disappeared at low tide. In the corner, written in blue ink, were the names of seven people who had lost a minute of their lives and never noticed.

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Chapter Four: The Watchmaker's Promise - continued

Mina remembered her grandfather saying that clocks were not machines for measuring time. They were promises that tomorrow would arrive in the proper order. If the harbor bell was wrong, then someone had broken a promise large enough for the whole town to hear.

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Chapter Five: Under the Glass Moon

That night the moon looked as thin as blown glass. Mina and Tomas followed the map to a locked door behind the fish market. The brass key turned once, then twice, then backward. Beyond the door, the tide hung in the air like a curtain of silver threads.

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Chapter Six: The Room of Borrowed Hours - continued

Inside was a room filled with clocks that had no hands. Each one ticked in a different voice. One sounded like Mina's mother laughing. One sounded like Tomas dropping a cup when he was six. One sounded like a storm that had not happened yet.

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Chapter Seven: What the Tide Remembered

The silver tide showed them scenes from the town: a baker hiding a letter, a mayor erasing a debt, a child returning a stolen compass. Every secret had been traded for time. Every borrowed hour had made the harbor bell less certain.

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Chapter Eight: The Gear Marked Return - continued

Mina found the missing gear in her coat pocket, though she had never placed it there. It was warm and heavy. The word RETURN was engraved along its rim. Tomas wanted to run, but the room had already begun to fold around them like paper.

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Chapter Nine: A Minute Honestly Paid

To repair the clock, someone had to give back a minute without asking what it would cost. Mina thought of the minute before her grandfather died, when she had refused to enter his room because she was angry. She placed that minute into the gear.

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Chapter Ten: The Proper Order of Dawn - continued

The tower rang once at sunrise. Not twelve times, not backward, just once. The harbor woke quietly. People remembered the apologies they owed and the promises they had postponed. Mina kept the brass key, but she never again used a clock without listening first.

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